

CHALKLINE — Business Plan

Measured, not guessed.

Version 3 · 16 August 2026 · reviewed every Sunday

Company name and tagline are read from `BRAND.md`. Rename there, and every document follows — nothing in this repo hardcodes the name.

1. The company

One brand. Four modules. One customer type: trade and local service businesses.

The mistake would be to build a takeoff company. Takeoffs are the wedge — the thing that gets us in the ute, on the phone, and trusted with a job that matters. What the customer actually has is a *business* with holes in it, and measuring plans is only the first one we can plug.

So: four modules under one brand, sold to the same person. **Every trade has at least one entry door**, which matters because takeoffs only serve measuring trades. An electrician can't buy a takeoff — he can buy M2 on the same day, from the same person.

	Module	What it is	Who it's for	Pricing shape	Status
M1	TAKEOFFS	Plans in, numbers back same day	Measuring trades — tilers, painters, flooring, waterproofers, renderers	Per job, or a monthly 10-pack	LIVE — validation phase
M2	NEVER MISS A JOB	Missed-call text-back and automatic quote chasing, configured inside the ServiceM8 or Tradify they already own	Every trade — the entry door for counting trades like electricians and plumbers	Setup fee + monthly	Unlocks when the pain audit shows demand
M3	GET FOUND	Website, Google Business Profile, reviews engine	Every trade	One-off build + small monthly	Unlocks when the owed client site ships and becomes the portfolio piece
M4	LOOK THE PART	Branded quote templates, plus content cut from their own job photos	Every trade	Add-on	Sold at takeoff delivery from day one

Two things make this a company rather than a list of services.

M2 is configured, not built. We don't sell software. ServiceM8 and Tradify already have missed-call text-back and quote follow-up; most tradies have never turned them on, and won't, because the settings screen is one more evening job. We charge to make the tool they already pay for actually work. That is a setup fee and a monthly, with no product to maintain.

M4 sells itself at delivery. The moment a tradie is holding a takeoff that looks better than anything else in his inbox, the natural next sentence is *"want your quotes to look like this?"* No new meeting, no new lead, no new trust to build.

2. The tiers, restated

Unchanged and still locked. **We do not skip ahead**, and the last one is a maybe.

Tier 1 — the operator-run service IS the business. Plans in by text, email or WhatsApp; a person runs the pipeline, reviews the output, sends a branded PDF back the same day; priced per job. Human sign-off on every job is what makes the accuracy claim keepable.

Tier 2 — a front door, when volume demands it. A dedicated number and a simple page feeding the same queue. Plumbing, not a product. Triggered by volume, not ambition.

Tier 3 — hosted subscription, only if demand pulls it. Seats for larger outfits who want to manage their own queue. Built only when customers ask and the per-job model is straining — never because it looks like a better multiple. It trades away human sign-off, so it gets its own accuracy bar first.

The software itself is never sold. Not licensed, not white-labelled, not on-prem, not as an API, and never as a one-time exe. It will be asked for. The answer is *we'll do the takeoff*.

3. Pricing and bundles

Enquiry-based and negotiable by design at this stage. The site shows "**from**" prices only. That is a deliberate choice, not indecision: we have five discovery conversations to run before we know what any of this is worth, and a published price list would freeze the answer before we've heard it. It also keeps every enquiry a conversation, which is where the other three modules get sold.

Indicative, to be replaced by discovery:

	Product	From	Notes
M1	Takeoff — wet-areas pack	\$30–50	One to three wet areas: floors, walls, niches, skirting
M1	Takeoff — whole-house interior	\$80–150	Every room, one trade
—	Any single module, standalone	—	Nobody is forced into a bundle
Bundle	TRADE PACK — takeoff quota + M2	~\$200–250/mo	The measuring trades' default
Bundle	WHOLE KIT — all four modules	setup + ~\$350/mo	The full business, one supplier

Bundles get discounts. The whole point of four modules is that the second one costs us almost nothing to deliver to someone we're already serving, and the discount should say so.

Final numbers set by discovery. Anchor between the hour he saves and the **\$200+** a human estimator charges for one takeoff — which is roughly what a whole month of the TRADE PACK costs.

4. The revenue math

30 clients at an average of \$250/month = \$7,500/month recurring — before a single per-job takeoff is invoiced.

That is the number this plan turns on, and the reason it's worth writing down is the size of it: **30 tradies is one suburb's worth**. Not a market, not a category, not a funnel — thirty people, most of whom can be met face to face inside a month of ordinary work.

Clients	Avg/month	Recurring/month	Recurring/year
10	\$250	\$2,500	\$30,000
30	\$250	\$7,500	\$90,000
50	\$250	\$12,500	\$150,000

Per-job takeoffs sit **on top** of that, and so does every M4 add-on sold at delivery.

The \$10K/month mission is therefore not a growth-hacking problem. It's **thirty relationships and a Sunday review**, which is a completely different kind of work and one that suits the distribution we actually have.

5. Scale rings — measure the house once, sell the answer N times

The product is measured geometry. Once a house is measured, the geometry is done and it never changes. What changes is which surfaces a trade cares about and how the numbers are re-cut. The expensive part happens once; the answer sells N times.

Ring 1 — adjacent measuring trades

Already measured. No new method, no new drawings, no new intake.

Trade	What they get	Where it comes from
Flooring	Floor m ² per room + skirting in lineal metres	The floor polygons and room perimeters
Waterproofing	Wet zones — shower areas, hobs, upturns, floor extents	The shower alcoves and bath platforms already deducted from the tiler's floor
Rendering / plastering	Wall m ² + ceiling m ²	The wall runs and gross floor polygons

Sold as a **re-cut add-on**: *"I've already measured this house for the tiler — want the render quantities?"* Near-zero marginal cost, and it raises the value of a sale we already made.

Ring 2 — upstream

Where one relationship buys many jobs.

Small builders buy a **whole-house measured pack** that all their subs price from. The benefit to the builder is that every quote he receives is priced off the *same* numbers, so he compares subs on rate rather than on who measured optimistically. Recurring, not a job.

Interior designers bundle a takeoff with every drawing issue. It makes their set look more professional, gives the trades quoting off it consistent numbers, and — because our questions section lists every undimensioned opening — hands them a free QA pass on their own documentation before a builder finds the gaps.

Ring 3 — channels

Tile and flooring showrooms. Counter customers arrive holding plans and ask *"how much do I need?"* Today the staff eyeball it or send them away. Instead: the shop sends the plans in, a **co-branded takeoff** comes back the same day, and the customer buys the right quantity **from them**.

Why a showroom says yes: a browsing customer becomes a confident same-day order; correct quantities mean fewer returns and fewer short-supply callbacks; it's a service the shop down the road doesn't offer. One showroom can be worth more monthly volume than ten individual tradies, and it arrives with a supplier's endorsement attached.

Parked — count-based takeoffs for electrical and plumbing

Points, fittings, fixtures, runs: a different method, a different verification layer, a different set of sanity ranges.

Revisit on demand, not on enthusiasm. Note that these trades are not locked out of the company — **M2 is their entry door**, and it's live for them before any takeoff product exists.

6. Go-to-market

Portfolio-first

Nothing sells this like a finished document. **Every delivered PDF is the portfolio.**

The give-away rules, and they are rules because free work is where service businesses quietly die:

- **Free takeoffs: capped at 5.** Named as pilots, with a job to do — marked-up corrections and a testimonial.
- **Free audits and demos for M2: yes.** The audit *is* the sales call. Showing a tradie how many calls he missed last month costs us twenty minutes and sells itself.
- **Free website builds: never.** M3 is real hours with no marginal-cost story behind it. Discount it inside a bundle if you must; never zero it.

Distribution

1. **Daily face-to-face trade relationships.** The channel nobody can copy, and the reason the 30-client number is realistic rather than aspirational.
2. **Instagram, Facebook and TikTok**, plus **Australian tradie Facebook groups** — offer, never spam. Answer the measuring questions people are already posting. One salesy post gets you banned from the only room your customers are standing in.
3. **A referral line in every delivery**, in the PDF footer rather than as a campaign: *"Know another tradie who hates measuring plans at night? Send them my way — their first one's on me."* Trades are a referral market; this is the only distribution that compounds.
4. **The content engine.** Every anonymised job is a 30-second before/after video:

"This ensuite looks like 20 square metres. It's actually 10.7. Here's over a thousand dollars of tile you'd have ordered and never laid."

The plan on screen, the naive rectangle, then the real polygon. No music, no face required. It isn't advertising — it's a useful fact with our name on the end, and we generate one for free with every job. **Anonymised always**: no address, no client name, no title block.

The website

One website, four products, enquire-for-pricing. Built in one evening on the existing pipeline, the day **Gate 1 passes** — not before. A site for a business with no proven customer is procrastination with a domain name attached.

7. What it costs to open the doors

Under \$200. That is the whole barrier, and it is why the gates in §8 can be honoured without flinching.

Item	Cost	Note
ABN	\$0	Free from the ABR
Business name (ASIC)	~\$45–100	~\$44 for one year, ~\$102 for three — verify current fee

.com.au domain	~\$20/yr	Requires the ABN
One-page site	\$0	Built in-house
WhatsApp Business	\$0	
Total to open	under \$200	

From the first *paid* job — not before

Item	Cost	Why
Professional indemnity insurance	~\$40–70/month	We supply numbers people quote off
Properly worded terms	one-off	Scope, limits, and what a takeoff is and isn't

A tradie quotes off our number. If it's wrong he wears the difference, and he will look at us. Two lines of defence, in order:

1. **The confirm-before-quoting checklist** at the end of every takeoff — plus the questions section, the △ marks, and the rule that anything unresolved is *excluded from the order total* rather than quietly included. First, because it prevents the loss rather than paying for it.
2. **Professional indemnity**, for when the first line fails.

Deliberately staged: **no insurance until money changes hands**. Free pilots are framed as pilots and the exposure is a testimonial, not a claim. The month the first invoice is paid, PI goes on.

8. Milestone gates

Reviewed Sundays. Module-aware. Any module that fails its gate dies without ceremony.

Gate 1 — customer #1

Pass: Angus returns a marked-up takeoff **and names a price he'd have paid**.

Unlocks: **the site goes up**. One evening, four products, enquire-for-pricing.

Fail: he can't find the errors *and* won't name a price — neither accurate enough to trust nor valuable enough to buy. A polite "looks good mate" with no price is a fail.

Gate 2 — two weeks out

Pass: **5 pilots run, 2 converted to paid**.

Unlocks: **M2 gets built — if the pain audit demands it**. Not automatically. We ask the five pilots how many calls they missed last week and whether they chase quotes. If the answer is a shrug, M2 waits, whatever the plan says.

Fail: fewer than 2 convert within 30 days of pricing going live.

Gate 3 — month two

Pass: **10 paid jobs**. On passing, and not before:

- register the business name with ASIC
- professional indemnity on
- content engine live

The money comes before the paperwork and the marketing. Registering a name and filming content for a

business with no paying customers is procrastination with a receipt.

Kill criteria

- **Accuracy** below 95% after one correction round on 3 of the first 5 pilots → M1 dies.
- **Conversion** below 2 of 5 within 30 days of pricing → the paid model dies.
- **Intake** — more than 60% of genuinely submitted sets unmeasurable, and tradies can't get better files → M1 narrows to floors-only or dies.

On intake we now have data rather than a guess: of nine plan sets pulled off the open web, **two were genuinely unreadable** and **five could be measured for floors but not walls** ([STRESS_REPORT.md](#), round 2). The addressable failure isn't unreadability — it's missing internal elevations, and **floors-only is still a sellable product**. That materially softens the risk.

The Sunday gate

One hour. Four questions: what did the metrics do; did any kill criterion trigger; what did customers actually say, quoted not paraphrased; what is the single most important thing next week.

If a kill criterion has triggered, it dies without ceremony. No pivot in the same meeting. The criterion was set when we were objective; honour it.

9. The first 30 days

Weekday evening blocks, roughly 90 minutes after the tools, plus a Sunday review.

Week 1 — prove M1 on real plans

Day	Block
Mon	Finalise the sample takeoff. Read it as a tiler would, not as a builder.
Tue	Send to Angus. Two questions: mark the errors, name your price.
Wed	Draft the intake message and the three job questions.
Thu	List 15 tradies in the existing network — name, trade, how you know them.
Fri	Chase Angus gently if quiet. Prep the in-person ask.
Sat	On-site conversations. Ask the 45-minute question. Say nothing about software.
☉ Sun	GATE 1. Marked-up takeoff back? Price named? If yes → the site goes up Monday.

Week 2 — the site, and pilots 1–3

Day	Block
Mon	Build the site. One evening. Four products, "from" prices, enquire.
Tue	Fix every correction from Angus, re-issue free, log each as a test case.
Wed	Send 8 messages from the list of 15 — free-first-job wedge, verbatim.
Thu	Run and deliver pilot #2. Time it: that's the real turnaround number.
Fri	Run and deliver pilot #3. Offer M4 at delivery on both.

Sat	Face-to-face. Two more pilots booked. Run the M2 pain audit on each — how many calls did you miss last week?
☉ Sun	Accuracy? Turnaround? What did the pain audits say?

Week 3 — pilots 4–5, pricing discovery, first content

Day	Block
Mon	Fold week-2 corrections into TAKEOFF_METHOD.md . The compounding asset.
Tue	Run pilot #4.
Wed	Deliver #4. Explicit pricing conversation: <i>"what's this worth to you?"</i>
Thu	Run and deliver pilot #5.
Fri	Collect all five pricing answers. Take the median , not the top. Set the tiers and the two bundles.
Sat	Testimonial and one referral each from the two happiest pilots.
☉ Sun	GATE 2. 5 pilots run, 2 converted? Does the pain audit justify building M2?

Week 4 — pricing on, M2 if earned

Day	Block
Mon	Pricing live. Message all five: <i>"it's \$X a job now — want me to keep doing yours?"</i>
Tue	Referral line into the delivery template. Work the week-3 referrals.
Wed	Build M2 for the first customer who asked for it — missed-call text-back and quote chasing, configured in their ServiceM8/Tradify.
Thu	First paid job start to finish. Time it. Record the true cost. Fill in \$4 with real numbers.
Fri	Film the first 30-second video from an anonymised job.
Sat	Face-to-face on whatever channel actually produced pilots.
☉ Sun	30-day verdict , then Gate 3 in month two: 10 paid jobs → name registered, PI on, content engine live.

The 30-day verdict

	Continue if	Kill if
Accuracy after one correction round	≥ 98%	< 95% on 3 of 5
Pilot → paid within 30 days	≥ 2 of 5	< 2 of 5
Effective hourly rate	> on-the-tools rate	< it, with no path up

CHALKLINE measures from stated dimensions only. It never scales off the drawing, and it never guesses. That rule is the product, it is the tagline, and it is the business.